

parking, or near main arteries and shopping. Sales within the last six months from the time of your search will give you the best picture of the current prices and conditions of the market.

- Median prices: Again, domain.com.au/suburb-profile is a solid start, and the market data tab will show you the trajectory of prices. This is an imprecise science, but it helps you to understand how sizzling the demand in this postcode has been over time.

Are there no suburbs within your budget? Not a surprise, unfortunately. Here's your backup plan:

- Work outwards to the next suburbs over, sketching rings around the zones that put you as near as possible to your most wanted postcodes, so you can enjoy proximity to that lifestyle at a more realistic price.
- Return to the sold-price and median-price search. Add that data to your list, and a picture will form of where you can afford to buy.
- Do this every three to four months to ensure your view of the market is up to date.

A bridesmaid suburb is real estate lingo for a second-best choice. The spillover effect of popular postcodes improves the liveability and vibrancy of neighbouring burbs. Astute business owners – café and bar operators, mainly – eye off bridesmaid suburbs to open in and capitalise on the overflow of new residents looking for attractions and entertainment.

A neighbouring postcode that you otherwise might have passed on is likely to be on the cusp of regeneration, thanks to price growth a few kilometres either side. It's an inexact equation – how on earth do you accurately measure 'lifestyle'? – but in my experience in property, patience and compromise, in anticipation of improvement, are the first home buyer's strongest allies. Instead of being frustrated at what you cannot afford, welcome the opportunity to buy into a growth area, and maybe make some money because you picked it earlier than many others.

During your property search, contact local councils to enquire about planning permit applications around the street you're interested in. It's a loose overview, as best as you can forecast, about apartment developments, which often deliver cafés and supermarkets, or new shopping hubs on the way. What looks bleak now won't necessarily remain that way.